camp argues that the presence of nuclear weapons is likely to stabilize South Asia. Optimists believe that states' primary goal is to ensure their own survival and that states behave rationally, adopting policies designed to further their goals. Given these assumptions, optimistic scholars maintain that war between nuclear powers, which could result in the adversaries' annihilation, is highly unlikely. Thus, in the South Asian context, nuclear weapons greatly reduce the probability of Indo-Pakistani conflict, despite the two countries' antagonistic relationship. As Kenneth Waltz claims, both India and Pakistan "will be deterred [from aggression] by the knowledge that aggressive actions may lead to [their] own destruction."[41]

Pessimistic scholars argue that nuclear weapons will probably destabilize South Asia because of political, technological, and especially organizational factors. For example, the military services that control nuclear weapons may pursue their own bureaucratic and professional agendas while ignoring the larger interests of the state that they ostensibly serve. They may adopt offensive doctrines that appeal to military officers but can reduce crisis stability. Or they may employ safety procedures that are easily routinized but provide inadequate security for nuclear arsenals. Scott Sagan claims that "India and Pakistan face a dangerous nuclear future. . . . Imperfect humans inside imperfect organizations . . . will someday fail to produce secure nuclear deterrence."[42]

It is difficult to evaluate the relative merits of these positions. Scholars from the opposing camps have generally not grounded their work in the history and politics of South Asia. Indeed, they have explicitly downplayed the importance of such region-specific factors. For example, Waltz and Sagan believe that the behavior of new nuclear powers is likely to resemble that of the United States and the Soviet Union during the Cold War. According to Waltz, "Any state will be deterred by another's [nuclear] second-strike forces; one need not be preoccupied with the qualities of the state to be deterred. . . . In a nuclear world, any state—whether ruled by a Stalin, a Mao Zedong, a Saddam Hussein, or a Kim Jong Il—will be deterred by the knowledge that aggressive actions may lead to its own destruction."[43] Similarly, Sagan acknowledges that "there are differences" between Indo-Pakistani nuclear behavior and the